Sara Lee® Bread and U.S. Hunger Uncover Hidden Realities of Food Insecurity Through 'Empty Tables: The Hidden Reality of Food Insecurity' Report

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New report reveals Americans' desire to help fight food insecurity, yet many are unaware of the significant impact it has on families across the country

HORSHAM, Pa., Dec. 19, 2024 /PRNewswire/ -- As part of their multi-year partnership in the fight against hunger, Sara Lee® Bread and U.S. Hunger have released new survey findings that offer deeper insight into the scale and impact of food insecurity across the country, in 'Empty Tables: The Hidden Reality of Food Insecurity.' This report was designed to shed light on the staggering gap between Americans' perception of food insecurity and the challenges many families face – particularly amongst female caregivers – while also exploring the nation's willingness to lend support.

During the holidays, people traditionally spend time connecting with loved ones around the dining table over a homecooked meal, but for many American households, this isn't a reality. Food insecurity affects 13.5 million American households – equivalent to 1 in 10.[1] Yet, as noted in the report, only 24 percent of Americans recognize it as one of the top three most pressing issues facing American households today.

"Sara Lee Bread has always strived to support moms and families across the US, and this partnership with U.S. Hunger is extremely important to us to help amplify that commitment," said Nick Pitone, Senior Brand Manager at Sara Lee Bread. "This new data will help inform our future approach in how we support families facing food insecurity – and we hope it inspires meaningful action, providing a sense of love, comfort and community."

Key highlights from the report include:

Americans aren't clear on what food insecurity is or the extent of its impact.

- Almost 3 in 10 (29 percent) Americans say they are not at all/not very familiar with the term "food insecurity"
- 76 percent of Americans believe food insecurity is NOT among the top three issues impacting American households today

The majority are unaware of how common food insecurity is among the average American family…

- 38 percent of Americans believe households earning less than $25,000 annually are the income level that submit the most requests for food assistance, when food insecurity realistically impacts households that earn anywhere from $25,000 to 149,000 annually[2]
- 47 percent of Americans believe food insecurity is rare among the average American family (i.e. dual income household)

…and even more so in female caregiver households.

- Only 37 percent of Americans believe food insecurity is among the top three issues impacting female caregivers today
- Almost 3 in 10 (29 percent) Americans believe most food assistance applicants are unemployed, yet many female caregivers are employed – or have multiple jobs – and are still in need of support[3]
- 3 in 5 (60 percent) Americans are unaware that female caregivers are most likely to sacrifice personal meals

when experiencing food insecurity – yet nearly 90 percent of female caregivers sacrifice their own meals to feed their families[4]
- 38 percent of Americans think unstable housing is among the most common housing situation for American households who experience food insecurity, but a majority (58 percent) of female caregivers do have stable housing and still rely on food assistance[5]

However, Americans are eager for change. They have a desire to learn more and take action.

- 82 percent of Americans said they are interested in helping to fight food insecurity

"More than 13 million households don't know where their next meal is coming from, which can be especially tough around the holidays," said Rick Whitted, President and CEO of U.S. Hunger. "U.S. Hunger is dedicated to providing solutions that extend far beyond just providing food assistance. Our goal is to leverage these findings to raise awareness around the struggles of food insecurity and increase opportunities for both education and action."

U.S. Hunger specializes in addressing the root causes of hunger by uncovering deep human insights. Its mission also includes the 'Full Cart' program, which partners with donors, corporations, and communities to bring food and resources directly to the doorstep of those in need.

Fueled by their renewed brand purpose to feed the soul of the American family with daily acts of love, Sara Lee Bread pledged $1 million in funding and product to U.S. Hunger by 2025 - further strengthening its support of the American family. The alliance includes supporting the organization's 'Full Cart' program, in addition to meal packing events led by Sara Lee Bread and U.S. Hunger employees. Learn more about the partnership between Sara Lee Bread and U.S. Hunger here.

About Bimbo Bakeries USA
Bimbo Bakeries USA is a leader in the baking industry, known for its category leading brands, innovative products, freshness and quality. Our team of 20,000+ U.S. associates operates approximately 60 manufacturing locations in the United States. Over 11,000 distribution routes deliver our leading brands such as Arnold®, Artesano®, Ball Park®, Bimbo®, Boboli®, Brownberry®, Entenmann's®, Little Bites®, Marinela®, Mrs Baird's®, Oroweat®, Sara Lee®, Stroehmann® and Thomas'®. BBU is owned by Mexico's Grupo Bimbo, S.A.B de C.V., the world's largest baking company with operations in 35 countries.

Methodology
This survey was conducted online within the United States by The Harris Poll on behalf of Sara Lee® Bread from November 25 - 27, 2024 among 2,083 U.S. adults ages 18 and older. The sampling precision of Harris online polls is measured by using a Bayesian credible interval. For this study, the sample data is accurate to within +/- 2.8 percentage points using a 95% confidence level. For complete survey methodology, including weighting variables and subgroup sample sizes, please contact Sara Lee Bread.

References
[1]*USDA. USDA ERS - Definitions of Food Security. www.ers.usda.gov. Published September 8, 2021. https://www.ers.usda.gov/topics/food-nutrition-assistance/food-security-in-the-u-s/definitions-of-food-security/ Coleman-Jensen, Alisha, Matthew P. Rabbitt, Christian A. Gregory, Anita Singh, September 2022. Household Food Security in the United States in 2021, ERR-309, U.S. Department of Agriculture, Economic Research Service.*
[2]Sara Lee and U.S. Hunger - Lived Experiences of the Female Caregiver, Page 12
[3]Sara Lee and U.S. Hunger - Lived Experiences of the Female Caregiver, Page 21
[4]Sara Lee and U.S. Hunger - Lived Experiences of the Female Caregiver, Page 12

[5]Sara Lee and U.S. Hunger - Lived Experiences of the Female Caregiver, Page 14

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